Subject: Re: Potential network-wide evaluation and open research services for OAK-AI Hub
Date: Tuesday, September 15, 2026 at 9:57:39 AM Eastern Daylight Time
From: Neeman, Henry J.
To: David Molik, Neeman, Henry J.

This email originated from outside of K-State.

Many thanks for this information, David!

Regarding evaluation:

For a $12M proposal, typically the expectation is that the evaluator will be external to the participating institutions (or, in this case, the participating states).

That is, we'd be better served, from the perspective of reviewers, picking an evaluator that's in a state other than Oklahoma, Arkansas or Kansas, because such an evaluator would be considered unbiased.

(If this were a 6 figure proposal instead of 8 figure, I'd tend to go with someone closer to home.)

Regarding publishing:

Can you write up a paragraph about this? Let's propose this to the group.

Regarding Piestar:

My first question would be, what would it cost?

If it's a few grand a year, that's easy. If it's six figures per year, that's probably impossible. In between, harder to say.

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From: David Molik <molik@ksu.edu>
Sent: Monday, September 14, 2026 5:32 PM
To: Neeman, Henry J. <hneeman@ou.edu>
Subject: Potential network-wide evaluation and open research services for OAK-AI Hub

External Email

Henry,

I wanted to put a few resources on your radar that I think could be useful not just as part of K-State's contribution, but potentially as *network-wide services for the OAK-AI Hub*. Ultimately, I feel that getting the RDM and Evaluation centralized would be a cost saving measure, where every sub-grant would not have to pay for these activities.

OEIE: Office of Educational Innovation and Evaluation
K-State's OEIE provides external evaluation, assessment, and research support for large sponsored projects. Rather than each institution building its own evaluation process, OEIE could potentially support a common evaluation framework across the Hub, i.e., shared measures, data collection, analysis, reporting, and assessment of workforce development, training, adoption, and regional impact.

OPE: Open Publishing Exchange
This is my group in K-State Libraries. OPE works across scholarly communication, research data, repositories, persistent identifiers, open publishing, and related research infrastructure. I think there is an opportunity for OPE to provide a common layer of *open research and data-management support across the consortium*: FAIR data practices, shared guidance and workflows, persistent identifiers, dissemination of research and educational outputs, documentation, and longer-term preservation and reuse.

That could give the Hub a coordinated approach to open science and research outputs rather than leaving every participating institution to develop those practices independently.

Piestar
I've also recently started talking with Piestar, a Manhattan-based research administration and evaluation technology company. Their platform supports complex grant portfolios, evaluation data, outcomes tracking, and reporting. There may be a useful model where Piestar provides some of the shared technical reporting infrastructure underneath a network-wide evaluation effort, with OEIE providing the evaluation expertise and methodology.

Taken together, I could imagine these forming a fairly coherent set of shared Hub services:

- OEIE -- evaluation design, analysis, and impact assessment;
- Piestar -- shared evaluation/reporting infrastructure; and
- OPE -- open data, research outputs, dissemination, and preservation.

Dan and I have been discussing these pieces, and before we get too far into budgets or scope, I wanted to see whether this fits with how you're thinking about the overall Hub architecture.

If it does, I'm happy to bring the thought to the larger group and start sketching what a network-wide evaluation/open-research component might look like.

Best,
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Book time to meet with me